CITY ANATOMY RESEARCH REPORT

How austin.chat gets users

A growth plan for a free Austin things-to-do site, its Day Planner and its coming free classifieds

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Draft research report, 29 October 2026

A factual plan for the owner to act on and rewrite. Every number carries a label: FACT (sourced), ESTIMATE (arithmetic shown) or UNCERTAIN.

Five research notes and a site audit (about 250 source links) are in the site repository folder `docs/growth-plan/appendix`.

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DRAFT research report, 29 October 2026. Factual plan for the owner to act on and rewrite; all copy here is draft (owner writes all copy). Five research notes, a site audit and this synthesis live in `docs/growth-plan/`. Every number carries a label: FACT (sourced, URL in the appendix note named), ESTIMATE (arithmetic shown) or UNCERTAIN (could not be verified this session, owner to check).

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0. The answer in one paragraph

austin.chat has a bigger inventory than any small Austin guide (66 neighborhoods, about 6,700 businesses, about 1,950 dated events at 390 venues, a planner with its own routing engine) and almost no way for anyone to find it: no sitemap, no page descriptions, no share previews, no analytics, and every listing drawn by JavaScript inside an iframe, so search engines and AI assistants index roughly nothing. Users will come from three engines, in this order of payoff: (1) static pages that search engines can read, led by one permanent "this weekend in Austin" page, 66 neighborhood pages and a dozen itinerary pages, because that is exactly the query family tiny local sites already win; (2) the owner's own short-video machine, pointed at a pre-filled plan link every time, posted where links actually travel (Instagram, Pinterest, Bluesky, the Substack) and tagged to Austin places for TikTok's new Local Feed; (3) a classifieds launch that is deliberately narrow (free stuff and garage sales on the map, then student sublets in late April, then face-value ticket swaps before ACL and F1), seeded by hand and open to read without an account. Around those engines sit cheap, rule-bound channels: free event calendars, a Nextdoor Business Page, newcomer Meetups, Airbnb-host QR cards, three specific press contacts, one Show HN post, and a single paid test (Google exact-match search at an estimated 15 to 50 cents a visit). Paid listings, billboards, bus ads, Chamber dues and influencer fees are the things not to buy. Realistic targets if the plan is executed: 2,000 to 4,000 visits a month at month six, 5,000 to 10,000 at month twelve, with at least one in ten visitors starting a plan.

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1. Ten facts that shape the plan

#	Fact	Label	Why it matters	Note
1	The home page body is one iframe; there is no robots.txt, sitemap, meta description, Open Graph tag, JSON-LD block, analytics script or web-app manifest anywhere on the site	FACT (repo audit)	Nothing can be found, previewed or measured until this is fixed; it is week-one work	06
2	"things to do in austin" is held by Tripadvisor, US News, Time Out and Visit Austin; "things to do in austin this weekend" is held by Eventbrite and five one-person sites (ATX Weekly, Hey Austin, Austinot, 365 Things, austin-texas.net) that each keep one permanent URL whose title carries this week's dates	FACT (Bing SERPs 2026-10-29)	The weekend query is winnable by a small site; copy the single-URL pattern	02
3	365 Things Austin, the archetype small guide, gets about 7,600 visits a month, 58% from search; Do512 gets about 138,000 a month, 66% from search	FACT (Similarweb)	Sets the realistic range for year one and shows search is two thirds of a local guide's traffic	02, 05
4	TikTok launched a US Local Feed on 11 Feb 2026 that ranks on location, topic and recency and favors travel, events, restaurants and shopping from local creators; Instagram Map (Aug 2025) surfaces public location-tagged posts	FACT (TikTok newsroom, TechCrunch)	Place-tagging every post is free local distribution for the owner's existing video output	03
5	Links: TikTok allows one bio link and no clickable captions; YouTube Shorts allow no clickable URLs at all; Instagram allows 5 bio links plus Story stickers; every Pinterest pin is a link; Bluesky welcomes links; X deprioritizes them (Musk's own words)	FACT (platform help pages)	Decides where the plan link goes and why Pinterest, Instagram and Bluesky carry the clicks while TikTok and Shorts carry discovery	03
6	Every six-figure Austin "things to do" account is a daily feed of what is new (365 Things, Austin Report posting six times a day for 68 weeks, Visit ATX); none has a product behind it	FACT	Cadence and news hooks grow the audience; austin.chat would be the first Austin account where the plan is the product	03
7	Nextdoor's rules changed on 19 Aug 2026: promotion must come from a free Business Page (2 posts a month, 2-mile radius); personal-account promotion is down-ranked with a warning email	FACT (Nextdoor blog)	One claimed page, used twice a month, beats posting as a neighbor	01
8	Craigslist Austin live counts on 2026-10-29: free stuff 360, apartments 346, gigs 279, musicians 161, sublets 45, lost and found 37, tickets 19, garage sales 13; company revenue fell from about $1.04B (2018) to about $302M (2025)	FACT (counted on the public pages; Wikipedia, BusinessWire)	Garage sales, tickets, sublets and lost-and-found can reach parity with a few dozen real posts	04
9	Facebook Commerce Policies ban animals, job posts and weapons and restrict event tickets to approved sellers	FACT	Fan ticket swaps, musicians and gigs have no incumbent home on the biggest marketplace	04
10	A front-page Show HN is worth about 4,000 to 11,000 visitors over a day or two, then decays; ESTIMATE 2% to 5% of them are in Austin	FACT (self-reported post-mortems); ESTIMATE	Launch platforms buy backlinks and credibility with source-code buyers, not Austin users	05

2. What the site looks like from outside today

Counted from the repository on 2026-10-29 (commit f99518b). Appendix 06 has the detail.

What exists	Count	Can a search engine read it?
Neighborhood business files (OpenStreetMap)	66 files, 6,688 businesses: Food and Drink 2,010; Health and Beauty 1,303; Shopping 1,097; Groceries 782; Auto 726; Services 409; Things to Do 361	No. Drawn by JavaScript on the chat map
Explore layer (dated items)	1,955 items at 390 venues: movies 446, live music 286, parks 275, free and cheap 270, events and festivals 215, events 213, comedy 212, pop-up markets 36	No
Neighborhood polygons and chat geofences	95 and 65	No
HTML pages	39 index pages (apps, maps, tours, planner, chat, models, budget, data centers, AISD, news)	Partly. Titles only; one page has a description
robots.txt, sitemap.xml	none	-
Open Graph / Twitter card tags	none on any key page	Shared links show no preview
JSON-LD structured data	none	-
Analytics	none	Nothing is measured
Web app manifest	none	No "Add to Home Screen" on phones

The fix is a build step, not an architecture change: the data already sits in static JSON files and the repo already runs GitHub Actions that rebuild the places, explore, news, sports and ticker data. A `build-pages` action that writes static HTML pages plus a sitemap from those files is in the existing pattern (appendix 02, section 7).

3. The strategy: three engines and one asset

Engine	What it is	Why it is first-tier	Evidence
Engine 1: pages search can read	One permanent `/this-weekend/` page with dated title, `/today/`, 66 `/neighborhoods/<slug>/` pages, 8 to 12 itinerary pages, annual `/sxsw/`, `/acl/`, `/f1/`, `/ut-game-day/` pages, and one leaf URL per event with Event JSON-LD; each page ends in "open this plan in the planner"	Two thirds of a local guide's traffic is search; the weekend and itinerary queries have thin results; freshness (a weekly rebuild) is the strongest documented AI-citation signal; Eventbrite doubled event-page traffic growth after adding Event markup	02 §3, §4, §5, §9
Engine 2: the video machine, pointed at a plan link	Every video's plan exists at a stable URL with a map preview image before the video posts; that URL is the bio link, the Story sticker, the Pinterest pin and the Bluesky post; every post is tagged to an Austin place	Discovery happens on TikTok and Reels, clicks happen on Instagram, Pinterest and Bluesky; the Local Feed and Instagram Map reward place tags; the owner already makes the videos	03 §2, §5, §7
Engine 3: a narrow classifieds launch	Free stuff and garage sales on the map first (zero money, zero legal weight, a weekly Short); sublets near campus in late April; face-value swaps of transferable tickets when ACL and F1 tickets go on sale; everything readable without an account	Every successful cold start used a pre-existing group, one category, hand seeding and open browsing (Craigslist, Nextdoor, Marketplace, Depop); Craigslist's thin Austin sections are beatable; Facebook bans the categories a fan board can own	04 §2, §3, §7
The asset: the email list	The "this weekend" page, the Thursday video and the Substack issue are the same artifact	Do512's engine was 353,000 daily email subscribers (2018); 6AM City runs 1.3M subscribers across 25 cities; email is the one audience no platform can throttle	03 §1, §5

Everything in sections 4 to 8 feeds one of these four.

4. Channel inventory

Priority: **A** = do in the first 30 days, **B** = days 30 to 90, **C** = later or only with a trigger, **No** = do not buy or do.

4.1 Search and discovery surfaces

Channel	Cost	Rules that matter	What to do	Priority	Note
robots.txt and sitemap.xml	$0	Allow Googlebot, Bingbot, OAI-SearchBot and PerplexityBot; true `lastmod` only; Google ignores priority and changefreq	Generate the sitemap in the build action; sitemap line in robots	A	02 §7
Google Search Console and Bing Webmaster Tools	$0	ChatGPT and Copilot read Bing's index	Verify both; add an IndexNow ping to the build action so Bing sees each weekly rebuild	A	02 §5
Home page HTML	$0	Google follows only real `<a href>` links; iframe content is a separate document	H1 "Things to do in Austin", three sentences, meta description, links to this-weekend, neighborhoods, itineraries, planner, tours; keep the map below	A	02 §7
Open Graph image and description on every page	$0	-	Plan pages render a map image so links preview as a map in DMs, Bluesky, Pinterest	A	03 §5
`/this-weekend/` and `/today/`	$0	One permanent URL; dates in the title and H1; content changes inside the URL; visible "Updated <date>"	Rebuilt every Thursday by the existing data action from the explore layer; archive copies at `/weekends/<date>/`	A	02 §3, §4
Event leaf pages with Event JSON-LD	$0	One unique URL per event; physical public events only; never hours, happy hours or promos as events (Google may take manual action)	Generate `/events/<id>/` from the explore layer	B	02 §4.2
66 neighborhood pages	$0	Listing text (names, addresses, hours, website links) must be in the initial HTML; map loads after first paint	Pre-render from `chat/data/places/*.json` with ItemList JSON-LD	B	02 §4.1
Itinerary pages (3-day, 1-day South Congress, East Austin night, with kids, bachelorette, SXSW no-badge, ACL and F1 weekend)	$0	Each page needs a task (the planner CTA) or it reads as thin programmatic content	Owner writes 8 to 12; each opens pre-filled in the planner	B	02 §4.1
Apple Business Connect	$0	Open to online-only businesses	Register the brand	B	02 §4.2
Google Business Profile	$0	Online-only brands are ineligible; profiles get suspended	Do not create one	No	02 §10
Google "Things to do" modules and travel carousels	-	Attractions and tour operators only; carousel beta is EEA, Türkiye, South Africa only	Nothing to feed	No	02 §4.2

Channel	Cost	Rules that matter	What to do	Priority	Note
llms.txt and "AI SEO" vendors	-	Google: no AI text files needed; Mueller: no AI system uses llms.txt	Skip; AI referrals are 0.37% of travel-site traffic	No	02 §5
Pinterest business account	$0	Every pin links; 8 in 10 weekly users plan summer trips there; travel searches spike at New Year	One tall pin per itinerary and neighborhood page; boards per crowd; March content pinned in January	A	02 §6, 03 §2
YouTube search	$0	Shorts carry no clickable links; long-form links need "advanced features" verification	Verify the channel; one evergreen "how to plan your Austin weekend" long-form whose description links; every Short's related-video link points to it; titles copy the winners ("N things to do in Austin", "weekend in Austin")	B	02 §6, 03 §2
Core Web Vitals	$0	LCP 2.5 s, INP 200 ms, CLS 0.1 on mobile	Defer MapLibre and Supabase until after first paint on listing pages; check in PageSpeed Insights	B	02 §7
Keyword volumes	$0	-	Check once in Google Keyword Planner (free account, no spend) and record in the repo; public volumes could not be fetched this session	A	02 §2

4.2 The owner's own channels

Channel	Link reality	What to do	Priority	Note
TikTok @anatomy.city	One bio link (1,000 followers or a Business account); captions not clickable; Local Feed ranks on place tags	Switch to a Business account; tag every post to the Austin place; weekly "this weekend on the map" plus daily 15 to 60 s neighborhood clips; say and show "austin dot chat"; rotate the single link to the current plan	A	03 §7
Instagram Reels, Stories, Map	5 native bio links; Story link sticker for all non-new accounts; location tags feed the Map; Trial Reels test formats on non-followers	Same videos; Thursday Story with the plan sticker; the 5 links = this week's plan, planner, tours, newsletter, classifieds; Trial Reels to A/B map-only vs narrator cuts	A	03 §7
Pinterest	Every pin links out	See 4.1	A	03 §7
YouTube	Shorts: no links; long-form: links after verification	See 4.1	B	03 §7
Bluesky (create @anatomy.city)	Links welcomed; Boston Globe saw 3x Threads' referrals	Post every map video natively with the link; the budget, data-center, AISD and absentee-capital maps fit its journalist and urbanist audience	A	03 §7
Threads and X	Threads: links allowed; X: link in the first reply	Cross-post only; 5 minutes a week	C	03 §7
Facebook Page	Links allowed, low reach; Reels live about 65 days	Cross-post Reels for the 45-plus, parent and newcomer audience; link in comments	C	03 §7
Substack	-	The Thursday "this weekend" email is the weekend page; grow the list from every plan page	A	03 §5
Own `/go/` redirects	-	Self-hosted short links with UTMs so clicks are counted in the site's analytics; skip Linktree	A	03 §5, 05 §6.3
Reddit	One honest "I made this map" launch post per big map, never a drip	See 4.3 and 4.7	B	03 §8

Formats with evidence behind them (03 §3): "this weekend in Austin" (fits the 3 to 7 day decay of TikTok and the 24 to 48 h peak of Shorts), "N things to do" ranked lists, a 60 to 90 s itinerary walk with the routing engine's travel times on screen (the format no Austin account has), neighborhood tours tagged to the place, negative-constraint titles ("that aren't eating or drinking"). The one documented penalty that applies to the owner is re-uploading TikTok exports with the watermark: "unoriginal or reused material" is ineligible for the For You feed. Render each cut from source.

4.3 Austin communities

Place	Size	Rules found	What to do	Priority	Note
r/Austin	about 640,000 (GummySearch)	UNCERTAIN: rule text not fetchable; third-party guide says self-promotion "heavily restricted", a weekly megathread exists; large subs commonly gate on 200 to 500 karma and 14 to 30 day accounts	Read the sidebar in a browser; modmail asking whether a free non-commercial map tool may be shared once; answer "Looking for" and "Ask Austin" questions with a plan link only when it is the answer	B	01 §2
r/austinfood	about 196,000	UNCERTAIN	Post the shopping lists (pizza etc.) as content; link the app in a comment if asked	B	01 §2
r/UTAustin	about 118,000	UNCERTAIN; "Events" flair exists	"Things to do near campus" map in August move-in week; sublet map in late April	B	01 §2
r/AustinClassifieds, r/AustinHousing, r/AustinMusicians	about 41,000 (+33%/yr), 13,000 (+90%/yr), 7,000 (+40%/yr)	UNCERTAIN; r/AustinClassifieds runs a Tickets Megathread	Participate as a person; once the board has real swaps, ask mods whether a "map of current Austin ticket swaps" link is acceptable	C	04 §1.6, §6
Nextdoor	"1,000+" Austin listings on its For Sale and Free page	Business Page: free, 2 posts a month, 2-mile radius or chosen neighborhoods; Groups set their own rules and are exempt	Claim a Business Page (UNCERTAIN whether an online-only site qualifies); use the 2 posts for a neighborhood's own page; join 5 neighborhood Groups as a person	A	01 §4
Facebook groups: Awesome Austin (20,000+), Austin Moms network (45,000+ across groups), Walking Moms of Austin (3,800, vetted), New to Austin and Girls New To Austin (sizes UNCERTAIN)	as listed	Most newcomer groups ban business posts without admin approval	DM the admin first; offer a "newcomer's first weekend" plan link; pitch AustinMoms editors instead of posting ads	B	01 §4
Discord: Austinites	4,803 members, grew by hosting restaurant meetups	Rules not shown on the listing	Join, read rules, drop the weekend plan in the events channel when relevant	C	01 §4
Meetup: New To Austin 20/30s (15,716), "I love Austin, but I need some friends" (34,072), Austin History and Culture (3,727); Austin topic 94,547 members across 41 groups	as listed	Group-run; starting a group needs an organizer subscription, ESTIMATE $120 to $180 a year	Offer the Moontower and 1885 tours as group walks to the History and Culture organizer; co-host a "plan your month" meetup; consider the one paid item: an "Austin walking tours" Meetup group	B	01 §4

Place	Size	Rules found	What to do	Priority	Note
Austin Newcomers Club	"hundreds of members", newsletter Welcome Mat	Terms UNCERTAIN	Email memberservices@austinnewcomers.com offering a free "first month in Austin" plan and a guided walk	B	01 §4
Neighborhood associations	City of Austin Community Registry lists every association with website links	Usually free community notices	Pull the list; email each its own `/neighborhoods/<slug>/` page and a one-line embed of the neighborhood map and, later, its classifieds feed	B	02 §8, 04 §5

4.4 Free calendars, newsletters and listings

All accept submissions; all list events, not websites. austin.chat must host dated things (tour runs, a monthly "plan your weekend" walk, a garage-sale map morning) to use them. Appendix 01 §3 has the submission URLs and rules.

Outlet	Cost	Rules	Priority
Austin Chronicle calendar	Free; do not buy the non-refundable promotion upsell at checkout	Curated, space-available; due the Monday of the week before the issue	A
Visit Austin event calendar	Free	Visitor-appealing events only; rejects daily tours, business activity, happy hours, networking, fundraisers, reseller tickets; 3:2 image at least 900x600; up to 5 business days; needs a link to your site	A (dated special runs only)
KUT / KUTX community calendar	Free	Supports recurring events	A
Austin Monthly calendar	Cost not stated	Account required; listings flagged "reader submitted"	A
ATXtoday (6AM City) events	Free upload; paid guaranteed newsletter slot	-	A
The Austinot	Free by email	Austin-based only; ranks #5 for the weekend query	A
Do512	Free profile; event-adding rights granted by email	Events only; about 250,000 uniques a month	A
Eventbrite	Free for free events; the Eventbrite page itself ranks	-	A
The Austin Common	Partner page is paid (price UNCERTAIN)	Civic and advocacy events	Pitch the budget, data-center and AISD maps as stories, not ads
Community Impact, Austin360	Submission pages not found (UNCERTAIN)	-	C

Outlet	Cost	Rules	Priority
Austin Chamber ($590 a year), Visit Austin partner programs ($300 to $8,000, no cancellations, no listing product)	Paid	-	No

4.5 Press

Local coverage of solo-made tools arrived three ways in the cases found (05 §1.4): the tool was the only live data in a news moment (ice-storm water map, COVID donation map), a civic or UT partnership embedded it (VoteATX on the city site), or the maker was quoted as a source (Austin Towers cited by KXAN). "Please cover my site" pitches did not surface as a pattern. Pitch assets, not the brand.

Outlet	Contact found	Angle	Priority	Note
Silicon Hills News	Laura@SiliconHillsNews.com (one editor; covered Austin Tech Map and ATXup)	"Solo maker builds a free Austin planner on his own routing engine"	A	05 §1.1
City Cast Austin	austin@citycast.fm; podcast relaunched 22 Sep 2026; runs Neighborhood Guides and monthly "Austin's Best" event guides	Day Planner as a "how to plan ACL or SXSW weekend" segment; neighborhood map for their guides	A	05 §1.1
KUT ATXplained	Hearken question form; listener vote	Submit a map-shaped question the owner can co-answer with data	B	05 §1.1
Austin Towers	Contact form; takes no ads; since 2007	The 3D city-project models page is exactly their beat	B	01 §3, 05 §1.1
Austin Current (replaced the Austin Monitor, which closed Oct 2025)	austincurrent.org/tips/ wants documents and data, not launches	Only the data products (budget, data centers, AISD) as evidence for a story	B	05 §1.1
365 Things Austin	Contact page; about 500,000 Instagram, 315,000 Facebook	A story: "a free map that plans your Austin day"; do not buy ads	B	01 §3
Austin Chronicle "Best of Austin"	Two-round reader poll; 33,055 voters and 423,142 votes in the 2025 final; nominations historically late March to early April	Ask followers to write in austin.chat when round 1 opens; ESTIMATE a few hundred write-ins reach the finalist list; no confirmed website or app category (UNCERTAIN)	B (spring 2027)	05 §1.2
KXAN, KVUE, Statesman/Austin360, ABJ/Austin Inno, Community Impact, Austin Monthly	Newsroom numbers and reporter patterns; no pitch guides fetched (UNCERTAIN)	Be the data source when news breaks; event-weekend "plan your weekend" angle 3 to 4 weeks ahead; ABJ wants the source-code business, not the free site	C	05 §1.1
Austin Monitor, KVUE Defenders line, Texas Standard without a statewide hook	-	-	No	05 §7

Pitch shape (recommendation, 05 §1.3): subject leads with the asset ("[Data] Where Austin's 47 data centers are, free interactive map"); five lines (what it is and that it is free with no sign-up; the one surprising number; link plus a square screenshot; "built alone, data from X, GeoPackage available"; a 10-minute call this week); one follow-up after three business days.

4.6 Partnerships and offline

Partner	What exists	What to do	Priority	Note
Airbnb hosts	Guidebooks are public, printable and shareable off-platform; Austin has 9,000 to 14,000 listings by counter, about 2,750 licensed	A one-page "give your guests this link" kit: QR card PDF plus a three-line welcome message; post in Austin host groups; hand to 10 hosts and 5 downtown concierges	A	01 §5, 05 §3
Bachelorette and wedding planners, hotels selling packages	Austin ranked #1 US bachelorette destination (Thumbtack 2015); Google "bachelorette" interest peaks mid-September	One bachelorette-weekend plan template; send to planners and hotels that sell packages	B	05 §3, 02 §2
Apartment locators and realtors	Free-to-tenant locator industry; realtors hand out newcomer packets; 2019-era "Austin apps" roundups by RentCafe, Built In, JB Goodwin still rank and get refreshed	Co-branded "your first 30 days in Austin" plan link; ask for inclusion in the next roundup refresh	B	05 §3, 02 §8
UT Austin	UT Marketplace is a free table for Austin businesses (confirm it still runs: UNCERTAIN); Texas Union ballroom exhibitor fee $350; the ISSS 2026 "Welcome to Austin" guide links to no external Austin site	Table with QR cards; email ISSS offering the neighborhood pages and a newcomer itinerary for the handbook	B	05 §3, 02 §8
Open Austin and ATX Hack for Change (St. Edward's)	Volunteer civic-tech group; the hackathon is how VoteATX got embedded on the city site	Present the routing engine and open-data maps at a meetup; enter the hackathon with austin.chat as the platform	B	05 §3
Downtown Austin Alliance	XOXO Cultural Curators pays creators ($125 at the 10,000 to 50,000 tier), a videography fellowship with stipend, and open calls for cultural programming	Apply when the next cycle opens; it is paid civic work the map-video skill fits	B	03 §4
Austin Public Library boards	Commercial advertising banned; librarian approval required; unapproved flyers discarded	Only as a free educational history map (the 1885 tour, the budget map), asked at the desk	C	01 §3
Coworking spaces, coffee-shop boards	No data	50 printed cards near UT and East Austin, with a partner's permission	C	01 §5
Visit Austin partnerships	Corporate sponsorships (Delta, Tito's); 14M site uniques, 30.1M annual visitors; no published listing tier	Ask one question about a listing tier; offer an in-kind planner embed; expect no free link	C	05 §3

Partner	What exists	What to do	Priority	Note
Airport ads ($3,500 to $25,000 per 4 weeks), CapMetro bus and shelter ads ($1,200 to $23,000 per location per month, now Clear Channel), billboards ($2,500 to $8,000 per 4 weeks)	Vendor estimates	-	No	01 §5, 05 §5

4.7 Launch platforms

Platform	Rules	Evidence	What to do	Priority
Show HN	Must be tryable without sign-up (austin.chat qualifies); no landing pages; no asking for upvotes; posts last about 2.9 h on page 1	4,000 to 11,000 visitors over about 1.5 days, then decay, "no direct conversions" in the best-documented case	One post, "Show HN: a free day planner for Austin on my own pgRouting engine (no sign-up)", 8 to 10 am ET on a weekday, lead with the routing engine and OSM data, stay in the thread all day	B
r/dataisbeautiful, r/MapPorn	[OC] with tools and data in a comment; [Interactive] in the title; "selling products is not allowed" on r/MapPorn (mirrors; re-read live sidebars)	Hoodmaps: about 200,000 users and 500,000 uses in two weeks from one coordinated Product Hunt, Show HN and r/dataisbeautiful launch with embeddable maps; 7% of users contributed	Post static exports of the budget, data-center and AISD maps as [OC]; the 1885 Sanborn and Ford maps and the 3D models page as [Interactive]; never mention source-code sales	B
r/SideProject, r/webdev Showoff Saturday, Indie Hackers build log	Promotion-friendly	Build logs rank in Google for years	One post each at launch; reply to every comment	C
Product Hunt	Company accounts prohibited; no upvote requests; 12:01 am PT	Global SaaS audience; a city site gets curiosity visits	Low priority; if done, frame as "an itinerary planner on OSM and open routing, Austin first" from the owner's personal account	C

4.8 Paid (framed as cost per visit)

Channel	Price found	ESTIMATE cost per visit	Verdict
Google Search, exact match on "things to do in austin this weekend"-type terms, Austin + 50 mi, mobile	"things to do in austin" about 140,500 US searches a month at about $0.15 CPC on a public Semrush page (UNCERTAIN, page garbled); travel average CPC $2.12 (WordStream)	$0.15 to $0.50 if the Semrush figure holds; $1 to $2 at the travel average; $100 buys 200 to 650 visits	The one paid line worth more than a one-week test: $5 a day for 3 weeks, kill above $1 a visit
ATXtoday (6AM City) self-serve newsletter	From $200; text ads $25 to $500; banners $25 to $250; live in 3 business days	about $1.10 a visit at $200 if ATXtoday has about 30,000 subscribers (guess)	One lowest-tier text ad with a UTM
Reddit Ads, community targeting r/Austin, r/askaustin, r/austinfood	$5 a day floor; CPM quoted $2 to $9 (UNCERTAIN)	about $0.80 a visit at $4 CPM and 0.5% CTR	One $5 a day, 14-day test, judged only on cost per visit

Channel	Price found	ESTIMATE cost per visit	Verdict
TikTok Promote	about $3 a day (UNCERTAIN)	Buys views, not visits	Only to push an already-performing map video to Austin viewers
Nextdoor Ads	Self-serve, near-zero minimum	Unknown CPM	$5 a day test for the classifieds launch
Meta geo-targeted	US CPM $10 to $15	$1.20 or more a visit	Only to amplify videos, measured as views
Community Impact (107,000 inboxes, 40%+ open), Chronicle Daily (54,212 subscribers, 28% open), Austin Monthly (65,000 print)	On request	ESTIMATE 150 to 230 clicks per send at 1% click	Ask prices; likely too dear for a free site
Micro-influencer posts	Collabstr 15,000-deal average about $198; Austin UGC from $25 a video	A 260-collab study measured +150 to +300 followers per collab, about one week's growth	Do not pay for followers; trade a custom plan map for a "guest itinerary" collab instead
Billboards, bus, airport, Chamber, Visit Austin programs, Linktree Pro, paid analytics	See 4.6	-	No

5. The classifieds launch

Appendix 04 holds the sources. The shape below is an ESTIMATE derived from the seven cold-start cases (Craigslist's 250-person email list and apartment wedge, Nextdoor's 90-house HOA pilot, Marketplace formalizing 450M group users, Nextdoor's Free Finds opening free listings to non-members and growing listings 80%, OfferUp metro by metro, Depop from magazine readers, Airbnb door to door) and three failures (Backpage seized, Oodle blocked by Craigslist within months, 3Taps and PadMapper enjoined and fined $1M for scraping Craigslist).

5.1 Order of categories

Phase	Category	Why	Incumbent to beat	Legal line to design around
1 (launch)	Free stuff and curb alerts on the map	Craigslist's largest Austin section (360); Nextdoor says 25% of its listings are free; about 70 walled Buy Nothing groups and a 15,990-member Freecycle list are fragmented; zero money means near-zero scam and legal load	Craigslist 360 posts; Nextdoor "1,000+" listings	none
1 (launch)	Garage and estate sales by neighborhood	Craigslist Austin has 13; Marketplace has no sale-event type; dated pins and a Saturday-morning use case; a natural weekly Short	13 posts	Texas: 1 to 2 sales a year or $3,000 of personal items before a sales-tax permit (one line on the form)
2 (late April, early November)	Sublets and lease takeovers near UT and ACC	About 45,000 UT students live off campus; r/AustinHousing grows 90% a year on sublease and roommate posts; UT's own tool needs a Facebook login; Craigslist has 45	45 posts	Fair Housing Act: free text only, no tenant-attribute drop-downs or targeting (the Roommates.com and HUD v. Facebook trap); Equal Housing line on every post; roommate ads are exempt (9th Cir. 2012)
2 (when ACL and F1 tickets go on sale)	Face-value swaps of transferable tickets	r/AustinClassifieds runs a Tickets Megathread; Craigslist has 19; Facebook restricts tickets to approved sellers; Texas has no resale price cap, SB 1820 died in committee, bots are banned (ch. 328)	19 posts	UT Big Ticket, SXSW wristbands and tampered ACL wristbands are non-transferable and APD has made felony arrests over wristband resale: show the venue's transfer rule on the form and disallow those
3	Musicians and gigs	Craigslist still has 161 musician posts; r/AustinMusicians grows 40% a year; Facebook bans job posts; on-brand for Austin, low scam rate	161 posts	none special
3	Non-pet lost and found	Craigslist has 37; pets already have strong city-recommended Facebook groups	37 posts	Link out to the pet groups; do not compete

Phase	Category	Why	Incumbent to beat	Legal line to design around
Later or never	Pet rehoming (rehoming-only, fee capped, link to the City's Home To Home), gig work (spam magnet), event rideshares, neighborhood services (lead-gen spam), personals, massage, firearms, animal sales	-	-	FOSTA killed Craigslist Personals in a week; Armslist litigation runs a decade; Austin bans public-space animal sales

5.2 Mechanics that drove adoption elsewhere

Mechanic	Evidence	For austin.chat
Open to read, gated to post	Nextdoor's Free Finds grew listings 80% by letting non-members browse	Everything readable and mappable without login; the existing Google and email-code sign-in only to post or reply
Map-first browsing	Craigslist Austin's list UI shows an 80.6% bounce (UNCERTAIN, subdomain estimate)	Posts are pins with a neighborhood, not an address; dated pins for sales; a campus-distance filter for sublets
Hand seeding with permission	Craigslist, Nextdoor, Airbnb all did it	The owner posts the first 30 to 50 real items (own garage, friends, a neighborhood association); never scrape
Email alerts and saved searches	Craigslist steers users from RSS to saved-search alerts; want-ads are the top flairs on r/AustinClassifieds	"Alert me when X is posted within N miles" by email (Supabase already there); a want-ad is a public saved search
Share card, not auto-posting	Marketplace let sellers cross-post to groups at launch	Every post gets an OG image with its map pin so posters paste it into Buy Nothing and neighborhood groups themselves; never auto-post into groups
Expiry and renewal	Craigslist: 7 to 45 days free	14-day default, one-click renew from the email, "claimed" button that keeps the pin grey for a day as proof of liquidity
RSS, GeoJSON and embeds per neighborhood	Oodle lived as a feed for others	A one-line embed for neighborhood-association sites: they are the HOA boards of the Nextdoor playbook
Weekly Short	-	"This Saturday's garage sales on the map" and "free stuff posted this week" are the seeding loop from an audience the owner already owns

5.3 Trust and legal kit for day one

- Safe-exchange layer: all four APD stations (HQ 715 E 8th St; Central East 812 Springdale Rd; South 404 Ralph Ablanedo Dr; North 12425 Lamplight Village Ave) plus Pflugerville, Manor, Round Rock, Cedar Park, Georgetown, Kyle, Buda and Lockhart police lots, shipped as a map layer. None of the incumbents show this on a map.
- Anonymous flagging with a two-flag auto-hide (Craigslist's model: about 50 staff ran about 700 cities in 2019).

- Phone verification only for housing, tickets and anything over about $200; one number per account, never displayed.
- Keyword blocks for weapons, adult, animals and MLM; a "no money changes hands on this site" banner.
- Section 230-shaped terms (you host, you do not write), DMCA agent registration at the Copyright Office, Equal Housing line on housing posts, a published prohibited list in the spirit of Craigslist's, no sale of data (Texas Data Privacy and Security Act small-business exemption applies; the one rule left is never sell sensitive data), no checkout ever (keeps the INFORM Act at zero countable transactions and avoids Lyte's custody collapse).
- ESTIMATE moderation load: at 50 new posts a day with verification, filters and auto-hide, 5 to 15 decisions a day, 15 to 30 minutes.

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6. The 90-day calendar and the Austin demand year

6.1 Ninety days (recommendation; weeks are the owner's working weeks)

Week	Build (Engine 1)	Video and social (Engine 2)	Community, press, partners	Classifieds (Engine 3)	Measure
1	robots, sitemap, Search Console, Bing Webmaster, IndexNow; home-page HTML and description; OG tags on every page	TikTok Business account; place-tag everything from now on; Bluesky account; self-hosted `/go/` links	Claim the Nextdoor Business Page; join 5 neighborhood Groups and the Austinites Discord as a person	Decide the two launch categories; write the prohibited list and terms	Umami Hobby plus the Cloudflare beacon live; UTM vocabulary and short-link table in the repo; funnel events wired
2	`/this-weekend/` and `/today/` built by the Thursday action	First Thursday "this weekend on the map" video with its plan link in bio, Story sticker, pin, Bluesky post and Substack issue	Submit the next dated tour runs to Chronicle, KUT, Austin Monthly, ATXtoday, Austinot, Eventbrite, Do512; Visit Austin for special dates only	Safe-exchange layer and flag button built	First Monday review
3	Event leaf pages with Event JSON-LD	Trial Reels: map-only vs narrator cut of the same plan	Airbnb-host kit (QR card PDF plus three-line message) to 10 hosts and 5 concierges; email Austin Newcomers Club and the History and Culture Meetup organizer	Seed 30 to 50 free-stuff and garage-sale posts by hand	-
4	First 20 neighborhood pages pre-rendered	Evergreen long-form "how to plan your Austin weekend"; verify the channel for links	Pitch Silicon Hills News and City Cast Austin; submit an ATXplained question	Soft launch: one Nextdoor Business post, one Short	Check Keyword Planner once; record volumes
5 to 6	Remaining 46 neighborhood pages; Apple Business Connect	Weekly cadence holds; one Pinterest pin per new page	Show HN (routing-engine angle), r/SideProject, r/MapPorn [Interactive] in one week, all UTM'd	Garage-sale Saturday Short every week	$5 a day Google exact-match test starts; one ATXtoday text ad
7 to 8	8 to 12 itinerary pages (owner copy); Trail of Lights template by 1 Dec	Guest-itinerary collab with one Austin creator (trade a custom plan map)	Email 10 neighborhood associations from the Community Registry with their page; pitch Austin Towers with the 3D models page	Neighborhood-association embed and RSS	Kill any paid line above $1 a visit
9 to 10	Core Web Vitals pass; annual `/sxsw/`, `/acl/`, `/f1/`, `/ut-game-day/` shells	Pinterest boards for SXSW no-badge and bachelorette (March content up in January)	Read r/Austin rules in a browser and modmail; one "I made this map" post if the mods say yes	Prepare the sublet category for late April; ticket-swap rules text	Month-3 review against the targets in section 7
11 to 13	Weekly rebuilds running unattended	Holiday plan template and Trail of Lights Short	UT Marketplace table (if it still runs); Open Austin meetup	-	Decide what to stop and what to double

6.2 The demand year (publish 3 to 4 weeks ahead; outlets run their guides 1 to 3 weeks ahead)

When	Event	Numbers	Content and pitch deadline	Note
January	Pinterest travel searches +300% month over month at New Year	-	Pin March content now	02 §6
Mid-March	SXSW	309,300 attendees in 2025; 2026 held near that	"SXSW without a badge" pages and pins by mid-February; City Cast and Chronicle pitches late February; press passes exclude brand content producers, so no credentials	05 §4, 03 §4
Late March to early April	Chronicle Best of Austin round 1	33,055 voters in the 2025 final	Nomination push to the owner's audience	05 §1.2
Late April and early November	Student sublet seasons	about 45,000 UT students off campus	Sublet map live two weeks before	04 §3
March to June, September to October	Bachelorette peaks; Google interest peaks mid-September	Austin ranked #1 US bachelorette destination (Thumbtack)	Bachelorette template live by late February	05 §3
August move-in week	UT	r/UTAustin about 118,000	"Things to do near campus" map	01 §2
September to November	UT football at DKR	capacity 100,119, sold out 2025 and 2026	Friday game-day plans	05 §4
October (two weekends)	ACL Fest	about 75,000 a day over six days; $557.8M impact in 2025	Content live by mid-September	05 §4
October (third weekend)	F1 at COTA	432,000 (2023); 2025 sold out, about 380,000 to 400,000	"F1 weekend off-track" plan; high-income, out-of-town, three days	05 §4
10 to 23 December	Trail of Lights	about 400,000 (UNCERTAIN)	Holiday template by 1 December	05 §4

7. Measurement

- **Tools (all $0 on GitHub Pages):** Umami Cloud Hobby (100,000 events a month, custom events) for the funnel, plus the Cloudflare Web Analytics beacon as a second opinion because ad-blockers undercount. GoatCounter is a free alternative. Plausible has no free tier.
- **Funnel events:** visit (by referrer and UTM); planner_started (first item ticked); plan_saved (guest or signed in); plan_shared; route_opened; a first-party localStorage "seen before" flag that marks returning visits without cookies or identifiers; classified_posted and classified_contacted once live; tour_started.
- **UTM discipline:** fixed lower-case vocabulary (source: tiktok, instagram, pinterest, bluesky, youtube, substack, reddit, hn, citycast, atxtoday, airbnb-kit, ut-marketplace, qr-card, google-ads, reddit-ads, nextdoor-ads; medium: social, video, newsletter, print, cpc, referral; campaign: the event or month); one `/go/<slug>` per placement so QR cards stay clean; never post the bare domain where a tagged link is possible.
- **Monday review, 20 minutes:** visits and Austin share; top five sources with planner_started each; the funnel ratios; returning share; classifieds posts and contacts; paid spend and cost per visit (kill above $1 after two weeks); pitches sent, replies, links earned; videos and templates shipped and which drove the most planner_started; one thing to stop, one to double. Findings go into docs/STATUS.md.

Benchmark	Numbers	Label
CityXee, a solo city guide, year one	42,000 visits and 130,000 pageviews, about 3,500 visits a month	FACT
365 Things Austin today	about 7,600 visits a month, 58% search	FACT
Do512 today	about 138,000 visits a month, 66% search	FACT
Visit A City (travel-guide SEO case)	28,500 to 199,700 monthly visits in six months by growing from 1,600 to 16,000+ URLs	FACT: scale needs thousands of indexable pages
Target, month 6	2,000 to 4,000 visits a month, at least 40% from Austin, at least 10% planner_started	ESTIMATE
Target, month 12	5,000 to 10,000 visits a month if the neighborhood and category pages are indexed and one event cycle (SXSW or ACL) runs with templates plus a City Cast or Chronicle mention	ESTIMATE

8. What not to do (consolidated, each sourced in the appendix named)

1. Do not post a launch thread on r/Austin without reading the sidebar and getting a mod reply; do not drip-promote there (01, 03).
2. Do not promote from a personal Nextdoor account; the 19 Aug 2026 policy down-ranks it (01).
3. Do not create a Google Business Profile for an online-only brand; profiles get suspended (02).
4. Do not mark hours, happy hours or promos as Event markup, and do not put Event markup on a list page without leaf URLs (02).
5. Do not mint a new URL every week or year for the weekend and event pages; the winners keep one URL and change its dates (02).
6. Do not rely on JS-only or iframe-only pages for anything that should be found (02).
7. Do not spend on llms.txt, "AI SEO" vendors or AI referrals as a channel (02).
8. Do not re-upload watermarked TikTok exports to Reels or Shorts; render each cut from source (03).
9. Do not paste URLs into Shorts descriptions or TikTok captions expecting clicks; do not put the link in the main post on X (03).
10. Do not pay for Linktree, followers, engagement bait ("comment for the link") or micro-influencers expecting followers (03).
11. Do not apply for SXSW press credentials as a brand content producer; they are excluded (03).
12. Do not seed classifieds with scraped Craigslist, Facebook or Nextdoor posts (3Taps: injunction and $1M), and do not advertise the board on Craigslist (04).
13. Do not launch personals, massage, escort, firearms or animal-sale categories; do not build tenant-attribute filters for housing; do not list non-transferable tickets; do not take custody of money or tickets (04).
14. Do not pitch the Austin Monitor (closed), the Austin Current with a product launch, or the KVUE Defenders line (05).
15. Do not ask for upvotes on Show HN or Product Hunt; do not launch from a company account; do not Show HN a landing page (05).
16. Do not buy billboards, bus or airport ads, Chamber membership, Visit Austin programs, the Chronicle calendar upsell, library flyers without approval, or Meta ads for site visits (01, 05).

9. Gaps the owner should close (could not be verified this session)

Gap	Why it was blocked	How to close
r/Austin, r/austinfood, r/UTAustin, r/AustinClassifieds rule text and megathread schedule	reddit.com and mirrors blocked for fetching	Open the about/rules pages in a browser; copy into appendix 01; modmail
Facebook group sizes and posting rules (New to Austin, Girls New To Austin, Austin buy/sell groups, Austin STR host groups)	facebook.com not fetchable	Check in-app; DM admins
Keyword volumes ("things to do in austin" and the weekend, itinerary, neighborhood and bachelorette families)	Public Semrush pages 404 or garbled	One session in Google Keyword Planner (free); record in the repo
Whether Nextdoor grants a Business Page to an online-only site	Not stated in the policy	Try to claim it
Visit Austin listing tier and price; Do512 and Chronicle rate cards; Community Impact single-edition price	Pages 403 or on request	One email each
Whether UT Marketplace still runs and its terms; UT orientation vendor terms	2022 listing only	Email Texas Student Media
Austin Chronicle Best of Austin: is there a website or app category in 2026/27	2025 PDF not fetched	Read the ballot when round 1 opens
TikTok's own link-in-bio rule page; Instagram Recommendation Guidelines page	Empty responses	Verify in-app before relying on the Business-account shortcut
Conversion rate of pre-filled itinerary links; Austin-specific creator rates; map-animation vs talking-head performance	No published data anywhere	The site's own analytics after month one

10. Sources

The five research notes and the site audit hold about 250 source links, each tagged FACT, ESTIMATE or UNCERTAIN beside the claim it supports:

- `appendix/00-brief.md` — the shared brief the agents worked from
- `appendix/01-local-channels.md` — Reddit, Facebook, Nextdoor, Discord, Meetup, calendars, newsletters, offline, precedents (Do512, 365 Things, Hoodmaps, Austin Towers)
- `appendix/02-search-seo.md` — SERP snapshots, competitor traffic, page programme, Google feature eligibility, AI-assistant citation studies, Pinterest and YouTube, technical constraints, local link targets
- `appendix/03-social-video.md` — Austin and other-city account case studies, platform link rules, formats and decay data, creator rates, the Toronto collab study, social-to-site mechanics
- `appendix/04-classifieds.md` — Austin classifieds landscape with live counts, cold-start cases and failures, category evidence, Section 230, FOSTA, Fair Housing, Texas ticket and privacy law, scam patterns, safe-exchange zones
- `appendix/05-launch-pr-paid.md` — outlet-by-outlet press table, Best of Austin mechanics, Show HN and Product Hunt rules and traffic, partnerships, the event calendar with attendance figures, paid benchmarks, analytics tools, review template, traffic benchmarks
- `appendix/06-site-audit.md` — what was counted in the repository on 2026-10-29

Method: five research agents, one angle each, 29 October 2026, about 90 to 140 tool calls apiece; synthesis and the site audit by hand. A printable PDF of this plan is beside it; `scripts/make_pdf.py` rebuilds it.